Master Degree Project

UNIVERSITY OF SKÖVDE

MECHANICS AS NARRATIVE: EXPLORING PERSISTENT GAME SYSTEMS TROUGH A PRATICE-BASED ARTEFACT

Subtitle

Master Degree Project in Media, Aesthetics and Narration A1E
One year Level XX ECTS
Spring semester 2026

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Abstract

This thesis explores how inherited and persistent mechanics can function as worldbuilding structures within a narrative artefact, without relying on explicit exposition or traditional progression systems. The study is based on *Soul Art*, an original practice-based narrative and system design artefact centered on reincarnation, inherited abilities, soul-bound weapons, and irreversible consequence. Using research-through-design and reflective practice, the thesis examines how mechanics can communicate world logic, identity, memory, and sacrifice through systemic continuity. The artefact was evaluated through qualitative reflective analysis and a small-scale pilot test with three participants. The findings suggest that participants were able to infer key aspects of the world's structure, death system, and thematic meaning from the mechanics alone. The study argues that persistent and inherited mechanics can operate not only as gameplay systems, but as narrative and worldbuilding structures within speculative game design.

Keywords: mechanics-as-narrative, systemic worldbuilding, research-through-design, persistent mechanics, narrative artefact.

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1 Introduction

Video games are increasingly understood not only as systems of interaction, but as expressive media in which meaning emerges trough the relationship between mechanics, narrative and player experience. Within the field of video game aesthetics and narration, scholars have explored how rules, systems, and player actions can function as narrative devices, communicating themes, values, and world logic without relying solely on explicit storytelling or linear plot structures. This has led to growing interest in mechanics-as-narrative, procedural storytelling, and practice-based approaches to narrative design.

This thesis is situated within this research area and investigates how game mechanics can function as worldbuilding and narrative structures, rather than as neutral or purely functional systems. Specifically, it examines how persistent, diegetic mechanics—such as reincarnation, inherited abilities, and irreversible consequences—can express themes of identity, memory, sacrifice, and choice. Instead of treating narrative as an external layer applied to gameplay, this project explores a design approach in which mechanics themselves embody the rules, values, and metaphysics of the fictional world.

The study is grounded in a practice-based artefact titled Soul Art, an original narrative and game-system concept developed by the author. Soul Art is a fictional world in which characters reincarnate across lifetimes, while they do not retain memories of past lives, they do inherit combat techniques bound to their souls. Power within this system is inseparable from cost: certain abilities permanently alter or destroy the soul, while others demand sacrifices that are not fully transparent to the user. The artefact is expressed primarily through written narrative, where story events operate as simulations of how these mechanics would function within an interactive system.

Rather than presenting a completed video game, the artefact functions as a narrative-based design prototype, allowing the exploration and testing of mechanics through story structure, character behavior, and consequence. This approach positions narrative writing as a form of systemic experimentation, enabling reflection on how players might interpret, emotionally engage with, and understand mechanics that carry long-term or irreversible effects.

The aim of this thesis is to contribute to ongoing discussions in game studies and narrative design by demonstrating how a written narrative artefact can be used to investigate mechanics as narrative and worldbuilding tools. Through a research-through-design methodology, the project reflects on the design of Soul Art as both a creative work and an analytical framework, examining how its mechanics generate meaning and support thematic expression.

2 Research Fields

This thesis is situated at the intersection of video game aesthetics, narrative design, and game studies, with a particular focus on the relationship between mechanics and narrative meaning. Within game studies, there has been increasing recognition that gameplay systems are not merely functional structures, but expressive elements capable of conveying themes, values, and world logic. This perspective moves beyond viewing narrative as a layer of authored content, instead emphasizing how rules, mechanics, and player interaction contribute to storytelling. Foundational work by Juul (2005) argues that games exist simultaneously as rule-based systems and fictional worlds, suggesting that meaning arises from the interaction between these two layers. Similarly, Bogost (2007) proposes the concept of procedural rhetoric, describing how rule-based systems can communicate ideas and values through their processes rather than through explicit narrative representation. Together, these frameworks establish mechanics as meaning-bearing structures rather than neutral technical components. More recent work in game analysis has continued to support the study of games as systems of meaning, where rules, mechanics, representation, and player interpretation are examined together rather than separately (Fernández-Vara, 2021).

A key research field relevant to this study is mechanics-as-narrative, which examines how game systems themselves can function as narrative devices. Scholars in this area argue that mechanics shape player interpretation and emotional engagement by structuring possibility, consequence, and agency. Through repetition, constraint, and feedback, mechanics can communicate ideas such as power, vulnerability, responsibility, or loss, often without explicit narrative exposition. Sicart (2009), for example, emphasizes that game mechanics structure ethical and experiential frameworks, positioning players within systems that implicitly define moral boundaries and costs. This approach aligns with broader discussions of procedural and systemic storytelling, where meaning emerges through interaction with rules rather than through linear plot alone. It also resonates with Salen and Zimmerman's concept of "meaningful play," where meaning is generated through discernible and integrated relationships between action and outcome (Salen and Zimmerman, 2004). More recent work on procedural and emergent narrative further supports the idea that narrative meaning can arise from systems, actions, and rule-based structures rather than only from pre-authored storytelling (Pons López, 2023).

Closely related is the field of systemic and procedural worldbuilding, which explores how fictional worlds are constructed and understood through systems rather than static descriptions. In this context, worldbuilding is not limited to environmental storytelling or lore, but is embedded in the rules that govern how the world operates. Jenkins (2004) describes games as forms of "narrative architecture," where spatial and systemic design contribute to storytelling. Expanding on this perspective, systemic worldbuilding considers how mechanics such as persistence, inheritance, or irreversible consequences define the metaphysical structure of a game world and shape how players come to understand its internal logic. Rather than describing the ontology of the world through exposition, systems demonstrate it through rule continuity and constraint.

Research in game studies has also focused on temporality, memory, and consequence as important components of how games construct meaning. Chapman (2016), for example, examines how games represent history and provide access to historical practice, showing how systems can structure relationships between past action, interpretation, and meaning. This perspective is relevant for studying long-term or persistent mechanics, where actions in one state of play influence future states in meaningful ways. Such mechanics challenge traditional reset-based models of gameplay and instead emphasize continuity, memory, and systemic consequence. In doing so, they transform worldbuilding into an accumulative and ontological process rather than a purely descriptive one. Nay and Zagal (2017) further

highlight the importance of consequence in games by examining how meaningful or inconsequential choices shape ethical interpretation, which supports this thesis's focus on irreversible and high-cost mechanics.

The thesis also draws on research in narrative design and player identity, which investigates how players form relationships with characters, avatars, and fictional selves. Murray (1997) discusses agency as a defining aesthetic pleasure of digital environments, while later scholarship has explored how identity emerges through systems of choice, repetition, and embodiment. Gee's theory of projective identity further suggests that player identity is co-constructed between player, avatar, and rule system, rather than solely authored through narrative exposition (Gee, 2003). Studies in this area explore how identity can be shaped through choice, repetition, memory, and embodiment within game systems. Persistent mechanics that carry information across deaths or play sessions challenge traditional notions of character progression, suggesting alternative ways of constructing identity that extend beyond a single narrative arc or gameplay loop. The concept of ergodic literature, introduced by Aarseth (1997), further supports this perspective by framing interactive texts as structures that require non-trivial effort to traverse, emphasizing the systemic dimension of narrative experience. In persistent systems, identity becomes encoded not only in narrative backstory but in rule-based continuity and accumulated consequence. Calleja (2011) also contributes to this discussion through the concept of incorporation, which describes how players become involved in game worlds through embodied, affective, and spatial engagement. Similarly, Isbister (2016) emphasizes how game design can shape emotional experience, supporting the idea that mechanics can contribute to affective and identity-based interpretation.

Methodologically, this project is informed by research-through-design and practice-based research, which position creative artefacts as legitimate sites of knowledge production. Frayling (1993) distinguishes between research into, for, and through art and design, identifying research-through-design as a mode in which creative practice itself generates knowledge. Subsequent design research scholarship has refined this perspective by arguing that artefacts can function as theoretical probes, revealing tensions and possibilities within complex systems. In the context of game studies, research-through-design has been used to explore speculative systems, alternative mechanics, and experimental narrative forms that may not yet exist as fully implemented games. This approach allows for the investigation of mechanics at a conceptual and structural level, making it particularly suitable for examining persistent and irreversible systems within a controlled narrative artefact. Khaled (2018) further supports this reflective approach by emphasizing game design as a process of asking questions rather than simply producing fixed answers. More recent design research by Höök (2021) and Redström (2021) also reinforces the value of embodied, reflective, and practice-based approaches to design knowledge.

Based on these research fields, this thesis understands inherited and persistent mechanics as structures that connect rule systems, narrative consequence, and worldbuilding. Figure 1 presents the conceptual model used in this study, showing how mechanics in *Soul Art* move from rule-based systems into narrative and thematic worldbuilding functions.

Soul Art Mechanics

(Reincarnation, Blade Call, Soul Arts, Soul Shape, Alchemist's Trick)

↓

Rule Continuity

(inheritance, persistence, irreversible cost)

↓

Narrative Effects

(character behavior, conflict, risk, consequence)

↓

Worldbuilding Outcomes

(world logic, metaphysics, history, identity)

↓

Thematic Meaning

(memory, sacrifice, fate, cost of power)

Figure 1. Conceptual model of how inherited and persistent mechanics function as worldbuilding structures in *Soul Art*.

This model illustrates how mechanics are understood in this thesis not only as gameplay functions, but as structures that organize world logic and narrative meaning. In *Soul Art*, persistence and inheritance connect individual mechanics to broader questions of identity, consequence, and the metaphysical rules of the fictional world.

By situating itself within these intersecting research fields, the thesis frames *Soul Art* as both a creative work and a research instrument. The project contributes to ongoing discussions on how mechanics can function as narrative and worldbuilding tools, particularly through persistent and inherited systems that embed memory and consequence into world logic. In doing so, the study extends contemporary debates in game studies by foregrounding permanence, systemic continuity, and inheritance as foundational design principles rather than optional gameplay modifiers.

3 Research problem and questions

Despite growing interest in mechanics-as-narrative and systemic storytelling within game studies, much of the existing research and practice continues to focus on mechanics as components of interactive systems implemented within finished or partially finished games. While these approaches have produced valuable insights, they often privilege technical implementation and player interaction over earlier stages of design, where mechanics are conceptualized, structured, and imbued with thematic meaning. As a result, there is limited research on how narrative artefacts—such as written fiction or narrative design documents—can be used as practice-based tools for exploring and refining game mechanics as narrative systems prior to implementation.

Although research-through-design and practice-based methodologies have been widely discussed and have legitimized artefacts as sites of knowledge production (Frayling, 1993; Zimmerman, Stolterman and Forlizzi, 2010; Gaver, 2012), relatively little attention has been given to long-form narrative fiction functioning as a systemic laboratory for mechanics. Existing work in speculative and critical design demonstrates how conceptual artefacts can explore alternative systems, yet these approaches rarely examine internally consistent, multi-chapter narrative worlds as structured environments for testing persistent mechanics over extended temporal arcs. This suggests a gap in the literature concerning the use of narrative artefacts not merely as illustrative storytelling, but as structured, rule-governed systems capable of modelling mechanics prior to technical implementation.

Furthermore, while previous studies have examined how mechanics communicate meaning, less attention has been paid to persistent and irreversible mechanics that operate across multiple states of play, such as reincarnation, inherited abilities, or permanent loss. Bogost's concept of procedural rhetoric argues that rules themselves make arguments, shaping interpretation through systemic structure rather than explicit narrative exposition (Bogost, 2007). However, much of this work has focused on moment-to-moment interaction rather than mechanics that extend consequence across temporal boundaries. Similarly, Juul's exploration of failure highlights the emotional and structural role of consequence in games, yet reversible failure remains dominant in many design models (Juul, 2013).

Persistent and inherited mechanics complicate these models by embedding history into the system itself. Rather than allowing progression to reset or restart, such mechanics carry forward memory, power, and loss across multiple narrative or gameplay states. From the perspective of the MDA framework, mechanics that persist across temporal states significantly alter long-term dynamics and aesthetic experience (Hunicke, LeBlanc and Zubek, 2004). They transform consequence from an isolated event into an accumulative structural condition. Yet sustained analysis of how such mechanics function specifically as worldbuilding devices—rather than as difficulty modifiers or progression systems—remains comparatively underdeveloped.

Another related issue concerns the relationship between identity and system design. Game narratives frequently rely on explicit characterization and authored plot to convey identity, memory, and personal history. However, Gee (2003) argues that identity in games emerges through interaction between player, avatar, and rule systems. Persistent mechanics offer an alternative model of identity construction, where repetition, inheritance, and constraint become the structural basis for continuity. In this context, identity is not solely narrated but systemically encoded. This perspective also resonates with the procedural and ethical dimensions of game systems discussed by Sicart (2009), who emphasizes that rule structures shape moral and interpretive frameworks. Nevertheless, further investigation is needed into how inherited mechanics specifically contribute to identity formation as part of world logic rather than player customization.

In response to these gaps, this thesis investigates how a practice-based narrative artefact can be used to explore mechanics as narrative and worldbuilding structures. By designing and analyzing *Soul Art*, an original narrative system in which mechanics such as reincarnation, soul-bound abilities, and irreversible sacrifice are embedded into the metaphysical logic of the world, the study aims to examine how meaning is generated through rules, persistence, and systemic continuity. Rather than treating mechanics as secondary to narrative exposition, the project positions inherited and persistent mechanics as foundational worldbuilding principles.

Research question : How can inherited and persistent mechanics function as worldbuilding structures within a narrative artefact, without relying on explicit exposition or traditional progression systems?

How can inherited and persistent mechanics function as worldbuilding structures within a narrative artefact, without relying on explicit exposition or traditional progression systems?

Together, this research question frames the thesis as an investigation into mechanics not only as tools for interaction, but as worldbuilding structures within a narrative artefact, capable of embedding memory, identity, and consequence directly into the ontology of a fictional world. By foregrounding persistence and inheritance as systemic principles, the study seeks to extend current discussions in mechanics-as-narrative and research-through-design toward a deeper understanding of how worldbuilding can emerge from rule continuity rather than descriptive narration.

3.1 Method

This thesis adopts a research-through-design methodology combined with practice-based research, an approach commonly used in game studies and design research to investigate complex, experiential, and emergent phenomena. Rather than seeking to test predefined hypotheses through quantitative measures, the study explores how meaning is generated through the design, articulation, and analysis of a creative artefact. This methodological orientation aligns with Frayling's distinction between research *into*, *for*, and *through* art and design, where research-through-design is understood as knowledge produced via creative practice rather than external analysis alone (Frayling, 1993).

Research-through-design positions the act of designing as a form of inquiry, where knowledge is produced through iterative creation, reflection, and critical analysis. Zimmerman, Stolterman and Forlizzi (2010) argue that design research can produce artefacts that embody theoretical contributions. Similarly, Gaver (2012) emphasizes that research-through-design does not aim to produce universal laws, but to generate situated insights through the construction and examination of artefacts. In this project, the design of the *Soul Art* system functions as both the research process and the research output. The artefact is not treated as an illustrative example, but as an investigative tool through which questions about mechanics, narrative meaning, and worldbuilding are examined.

Within game studies specifically, research-through-design has been used to explore experimental mechanics, speculative systems, and alternative narrative structures. For example, Flanagan's work on critical play demonstrates how game systems themselves can function as research arguments (Flanagan, 2009), while Bogost's procedural rhetoric framework illustrates how rule-based systems can embody theoretical claims (Bogost, 2007). These approaches support the methodological premise that mechanics can be studied not only through player reception, but through their design logic and systemic structure.

The methodological focus of the study is qualitative and exploratory. The research investigates how persistent, diegetic mechanics—such as reincarnation, inherited abilities, and irreversible sacrifice—can function as narrative structures by examining how these mechanics operate within a coherent system. Emphasis is placed on understanding how rules, constraints, and consequences shape narrative interpretation, rather than on measuring player performance or behavioural outcomes. This aligns with qualitative design research traditions that prioritize interpretive analysis over statistical generalization.

Reflection plays a central role in the methodology. Schön's concept of the "reflective practitioner" provides a theoretical foundation for this approach, emphasizing reflection-in-action and reflection-on-action as mechanisms for generating professional knowledge (Schön, 1983). Throughout the design process, the development of *Soul Art* is documented and critically analyzed in relation to the research question. This reflective process includes examining design decisions, identifying tensions or contradictions within the system, and evaluating how effectively the mechanics support the intended themes of identity, memory, and cost.

Case studies within practice-based game research further support this methodological approach. Experimental and art games have frequently been used as research artefacts to explore mechanics as expressive structures, demonstrating that playable or conceptual systems can function as scholarly contributions. By situating *Soul Art* within this lineage, the project positions the artefact as a structured design inquiry rather than solely as a creative product.

By employing a practice-based, research-through-design methodology, this thesis aims to generate insights into how mechanics can function as narrative and worldbuilding tools, while also demonstrating the value of narrative artefacts as sites of design exploration. The method allows for the investigation of speculative or unimplemented systems, which may be difficult to study through traditional empirical approaches. In doing so, the project contributes to methodological discussions within game studies by extending research-through-design into the domain of long-form narrative system construction.

3.1.1 The Artefact

The practice-based artefact for this thesis consists of *Soul Art*, an original narrative and system design project developed by the author. The artefact is composed of a multi-chapter written narrative, supported by extensive character profiles, lore documentation, and explicit descriptions of the underlying mechanics that govern the fictional world. At the time of writing, the artefact comprises approximately 44,000 words across 343 pages, including two completed narrative arcs of five to six chapters each.

Rather than functioning as a standalone literary work, *Soul Art* is designed as a systemic narrative artefact, in which story events operate according to a clearly defined set of rules. These rules correspond to mechanics that would conventionally be found in a video game system, such as reincarnation, inherited abilities, and irreversible sacrifice. This approach relates to the understanding of games as rule-based systems that can generate fictional meaning through their structures (Juul, 2005; Salen and Zimmerman, 2004). The narrative chapters function as simulations of how these mechanics manifest over time, allowing the exploration of their narrative and thematic implications without requiring full interactive implementation.

The narrative follows six protagonists within a linear chronology. Reincarnation exists as an established in-world phenomenon and is explicitly acknowledged and discussed by characters, rather than being framed as a player-facing reset or meta-mechanic. As a result, reincarnation is experienced by the reader as part of the world's internal logic, shaping character history, memory, and motivation across narrative arcs. This approach supports the investigation of identity persistence through system continuity rather than through structural fragmentation or nonlinear storytelling.

Core mechanics within *Soul Art* are explicitly named and articulated within the fiction, reinforcing their role as diegetic systems rather than abstract rules. These include soul-bound weapons, elemental affinities linked to personality, inherited combat techniques known as Soul Arts, and the manifestation of a soul's true form through Soul Shape. Certain mechanics, such as the Alchemist's Trick, are deliberately restricted in scope. Only the six protagonists are capable of using this ability, which allows them to sacrifice their own life force in exchange for power. This limitation establishes the mechanic as a rare and high-cost system, foregrounding themes of sacrifice, consequence, and unequal access to power.

The artefact places particular emphasis on persistent and irreversible mechanics. Actions taken within one narrative arc affect future narrative possibilities, while certain states—such as the permanent destruction of a soul—close off potential outcomes entirely. These constraints are used to explore how long-term consequence and systemic finality contribute to narrative meaning and emotional weight, aligning with the thesis's focus on mechanics as worldbuilding and storytelling structures. This also connects to procedural rhetoric, where rule-based systems communicate meaning through constraint, consequence, and process (Bogost, 2007).

While *Soul Art* was initially conceived as a video game system, it has evolved into a hybrid form that also aligns with serialized visual storytelling formats such as animation. Nevertheless, the artefact retains the structural and mechanical logic of a game system, including clearly defined rules, constraints, progression, and failure states. This dual orientation positions *Soul Art* as both a speculative game design and a narrative-based system exploration, allowing the study to investigate mechanics independently of a specific medium while remaining grounded in game design principles.

The scope of the artefact is intentionally limited to the exploration of selected mechanics and themes relevant to the research question. The project does not aim to represent a complete or finalized game system, nor does it seek to address player interaction or balance in a quantitative sense. Instead, the artefact functions as a bounded design space in which mechanics, narrative, and world logic can be examined as interdependent systems. This framing aligns with research-through-design approaches, where artefacts are used as sites of inquiry rather than only as finished products (Frayling, 1993; Zimmerman, Stolterman and Forlizzi, 2010; Gaver, 2012).

3.1.2 Evaluation of the Artefact

The evaluation of the *Soul Art* artefact is conducted through qualitative, reflective analysis, consistent with the research-through-design methodology adopted in this thesis. Rather than measuring success through usability metrics or player performance, the evaluation focuses on how effectively the artefact explores and communicates narrative meaning through mechanics. This approach aligns with interpretive traditions in game studies that treat games and systems as cultural texts subject to analytical reading rather than solely empirical measurement.

The primary method of evaluation consists of close reading and analytical reflection on selected narrative chapters and system descriptions. This mode of analysis draws from hermeneutic and textual analysis traditions, as well as from ludological approaches that examine rule structures as meaning-producing systems. Aarseth's concept of cybertext emphasizes that structured systems invite interpretive engagement through their rules and constraints, supporting the legitimacy of analyzing systemic structures as texts (Aarseth, 1997). Similarly, Murray argues that digital and interactive artefacts can be examined for their procedural and structural properties, not only their narrative content (Murray, 1997). In this project, narrative chapters are treated as enactments of systemic rules, allowing the mechanics to be examined through their narrative consequences.

These sections are examined as case studies in which mechanics are enacted through narrative events, character decisions, and consequences. Particular attention is given to moments where persistent or irreversible mechanics—such as reincarnation, inherited abilities, Soul Shape, and the Alchemist's Trick—directly shape narrative outcomes or restrict future possibilities. These moments are analyzed in relation to the research question, with emphasis on how mechanics contribute to expressions of identity, memory, sacrifice, and world logic. In this sense, the evaluation draws on Bogost's notion of procedural rhetoric, considering how rule structures implicitly "argue" through consequence and limitation (Bogost, 2007).

In addition to textual analysis, the evaluation includes design reflection, in which the author critically examines the design intentions behind specific mechanics and their narrative realization. This reflective process is grounded in Schön's theory of the reflective practitioner, particularly the processes of reflection-in-action and reflection-on-action (Schön, 1983). Through iterative reflection, design decisions are examined as sites of knowledge production. The evaluation considers whether the mechanics operate consistently within the system, whether they support the intended themes, and whether tensions or contradictions emerge between narrative expectations and systemic logic. Design decisions are discussed not as errors to be corrected, but as sources of insight into the challenges and affordances of mechanics-driven narrative design.

The evaluation also involves mapping mechanics to thematic outcomes, tracing how individual systems function across multiple chapters or narrative arcs. By examining patterns of repetition, inheritance, and consequence, the analysis explores how long-term mechanics contribute to the construction of character identity and world continuity without reliance on explicit exposition. This approach resonates with the Mechanics-Dynamics-Aesthetics framework, particularly in its attention to how mechanics give rise to systemic dynamics that shape aesthetic and interpretive outcomes (Hunicke, LeBlanc and Zubek, 2004). Absences—such as characters or narrative possibilities removed through permanent loss—are treated as meaningful systemic effects rather than narrative omissions.

Given that the artefact is not implemented as an interactive game, the evaluation does not include gameplay testing or quantitative empirical user studies. Instead, the evaluation combines reflective analysis of the artefact with a small-scale exploratory pilot feedback session focused on how participants interpreted the core mechanics when presented in simplified form. This decision is consistent with research-through-design methodologies that prioritize conceptual, structural, and speculative exploration over empirical validation in early-stage design inquiry (Zimmerman, Stolterman and Forlizzi, 2010; Gaver, 2012). The focus remains on internal coherence, systemic clarity, and narrative expressiveness at the level of rule construction. This approach is appropriate to the scope of the project and aligns with the thesis's aim of investigating mechanics at the conceptual and structural level, prior to implementation.

Finally, the evaluation acknowledges the limitations of the artefact and methodology. As with many practice-based studies, the findings are situated and interpretive rather than statistically generalizable. However, design research literature argues that situated insights can still contribute meaningfully to theoretical discourse by articulating design principles, tensions, and emergent patterns (Gaver, 2012; Zimmerman, Stolterman and Forlizzi, 2010). The analysis aims to produce transferable insights into how persistent and high-cost mechanics can be designed and evaluated as narrative structures, and how written narrative artefacts can function as valid sites for exploring systemic worldbuilding within academic research.

4 Planning

The development of *Soul Art* originated as a personal creative project, initially conceived as a hobby and an exploration of narrative and worldbuilding ideas. The project began without a formal research objective, driven primarily by an interest in creating a fictional system centered around reincarnation, identity, and the relationship between power and sacrifice. Over time, however, the project evolved beyond its initial scope, revealing a structured set of mechanics and recurring themes that aligned closely with questions explored within game studies and narrative design.

As the system developed, it became increasingly evident that *Soul Art* was not only a narrative concept but also a coherent rule-based system, with clearly defined mechanics such as reincarnation, inherited abilities, and irreversible consequences. This realization led to a shift in perspective: rather than treating the project solely as a creative work, it was reframed as a potential practice-based research artefact. In this context, the focus moved toward examining how these mechanics could function as narrative and worldbuilding structures. This reframing aligns with research-through-design approaches, where creative artefacts can function as sites of inquiry and knowledge production (Frayling, 1993; Zimmerman, Stolterman and Forlizzi, 2010; Gaver, 2012).

The planning phase of the project therefore involved translating an initially intuitive and creative process into a more structured design framework. This included identifying core mechanics, defining their rules and limitations, and considering how they interact within a consistent system. Particular emphasis was placed on persistent and inherited mechanics, as these were central to both the narrative premise and the emerging research focus. Early design considerations explored how such mechanics could carry meaning across time, influence character identity, and shape the internal logic of the world without relying on explicit exposition. This connects to procedural rhetoric and meaningful play, where rules and system outcomes are understood as central to how games generate meaning (Bogost, 2007; Salen and Zimmerman, 2004).

Another important aspect of the planning phase was the decision regarding the form of the artefact. While *Soul Art* was originally conceived as a potential video game, practical and conceptual considerations led to the choice of developing it as a written narrative system. This decision allowed for greater flexibility in exploring complex mechanics, long-term consequences, and multi-layered worldbuilding without the technical constraints of full implementation. At the same time, the project retained a game-oriented structure, ensuring that mechanics remained clearly defined, consistent, and central to the experience.

Scope definition played a significant role in the planning process. Given the complexity of the system, it was necessary to focus on a subset of mechanics that were most relevant to the research question. In particular, the project prioritizes mechanics related to persistence, inheritance, and irreversible cost, as these directly relate to themes of memory, identity, and sacrifice. Other potential aspects of a full game system, such as balance, user interface design, or large-scale player interaction, were intentionally excluded in order to maintain a clear research focus.

Finally, the planning phase involved aligning the project with the theoretical and methodological framework of the thesis. This included positioning *Soul Art* within existing research fields such as mechanics-as-narrative, systemic worldbuilding, and research-through-design. By doing so, the project transitioned from a personal creative endeavor into a structured research investigation, while still retaining the original creative motivations that informed its design.

5 Production

The production of *Soul Art* involved the parallel development of narrative content and systemic design, with both elements informing and shaping each other throughout the process. Rather than treating story and mechanics as separate layers, the project was developed with the intention of integrating them into a unified system in which narrative events emerge from rule-based structures.

The primary form of production consisted of writing a multi-chapter narrative supported by detailed character profiles, lore documentation, and explicit descriptions of core mechanics. At the time of writing, the artefact includes approximately 44,000 words across 343 pages, organized into two narrative arcs with five to six chapters each. These chapters function not only as story segments but as instances of system execution, in which mechanics are enacted through character decisions, interactions, and consequences.

Alongside the narrative writing, significant effort was dedicated to the development and refinement of the system's core mechanics. These include reincarnation, soul-bound weapons, elemental affinities, inherited abilities, and high-cost mechanics such as irreversible soul destruction and life-force exchange For example, in *Soul Art*, Soul Shape allows a character to manifest the full truth of their soul as either a domain or construct. While this grants exceptional power, death in this state permanently destroys the soul, preventing reincarnation. This makes the mechanic both a combat escalation and a worldbuilding rule: the world is structured around the fear that power can end not only the body, but the soul itself. This rule introduces a direct and irreversible consequence that shapes both character behavior and narrative outcomes. Each mechanic was defined with clear rules, limitations, and implications, ensuring internal consistency across the system. Particular attention was given to how these mechanics interact over time, especially in relation to persistence and inheritance. This design approach reflects Bogost's concept of procedural rhetoric, where systems communicate meaning through their rules, as well as Salen and Zimmerman's notion of meaningful play, in which outcomes are directly tied to player action and system logic (Bogost, 2007; Salen and Zimmerman, 2004).

The production process was iterative, with continuous movement between system design and narrative implementation. Mechanics were often first conceptualized at an abstract level and then tested through narrative scenarios, allowing their implications to be explored in practice. Conversely, narrative developments sometimes revealed inconsistencies or limitations within the system, prompting revisions to the underlying mechanics. This iterative loop reflects the principles of research-through-design, where knowledge emerges through cycles of creation and reflection (Frayling, 1993; Zimmerman, Stolterman and Forlizzi, 2010; Gaver, 2012).

A key design focus during production was maintaining systemic coherence across extended narrative structures. This can be seen in the reincarnation system, where characters may not consciously remember past lives, but still display inherited combat instincts, weapon affinities, and recurring emotional tendencies. The mechanic is therefore not only explained as lore, but repeatedly enacted through character behavior. This ensures that reincarnation is not only described as a concept but continuously enacted through narrative events. Similarly, the consequences of high-cost abilities are preserved across arcs, with characters avoiding or hesitating to use Soul Shape due to its permanent risk, reinforcing the system's internal consistency. Because the project emphasizes persistent and inherited mechanics, it was necessary to ensure that rules remained consistent across multiple chapters and arcs. This required careful tracking of character states, abilities, and consequences, as well as consideration of how past events influence future possibilities. In this sense, the production

process involved not only writing narrative content but also managing a dynamic system with long-term continuity.

The integration of mechanics into the narrative was handled explicitly. Mechanics are named, understood, and discussed within the world, allowing them to function as diegetic elements rather than abstract gameplay systems. This design choice reinforces the role of mechanics as worldbuilding structures, ensuring that rules are perceived as part of the world's internal logic rather than external constructs imposed on it.

In addition to system consistency, production decisions were guided by thematic considerations. Mechanics were not only evaluated based on functionality but also on how effectively they contributed to themes of identity, memory, sacrifice, and consequence. For example, high-cost mechanics such as life-force exchange were designed to introduce meaningful trade-offs, while irreversible outcomes such as permanent soul destruction were used to reinforce the weight of long-term consequences. These design choices ensured alignment between mechanical structure and narrative intent.

Finally, the production process involved the gradual expansion of the artefact beyond narrative chapters to include supporting materials such as character profiles and system documentation. These elements provide additional clarity regarding the mechanics and their relationships, functioning as a form of internal design reference. Together, the narrative and supporting materials form a cohesive artefact that operates as both a story and a structured system.

6 Reflections

The development and evaluation of *Soul Art* revealed both the strengths and challenges of designing mechanics as narrative and worldbuilding structures. Reflective analysis of the artefact, combined with external feedback, provides insight into how effectively the system communicates its underlying logic without reliance on explicit exposition.

A central aim of the project was to examine whether inherited and persistent mechanics could function as primary carriers of worldbuilding. Through the design and implementation process, it became evident that such mechanics inherently produce a sense of continuity and internal logic. By embedding memory, identity, and consequence directly into the system, the world of *Soul Art* is not only described but demonstrated through its rules. This connects to procedural rhetoric, where systems communicate meaning through rules, processes, and consequences rather than direct explanation (Bogost, 2007).

To complement the author's reflective analysis, a small-scale qualitative feedback session was conducted with three participants. A simplified version of the *Soul Art* core system used during pilot testing is included in Appendix A. The pilot testing was designed specifically to evaluate whether core mechanics could communicate worldbuilding concepts independently of explicit narrative context. Rather than broadly assessing user experience, the testing focused on how participants interpret systemic rules, persistence, and consequence when presented in isolation. This refinement ensures closer alignment between the research method and the central research question. Participants were provided with a simplified description of the core system and asked to interpret how the world operates, as well as to reflect on its risks and distinguishing features. The goal of this exercise was not to measure correctness, but to evaluate how effectively the mechanics communicate worldbuilding concepts independently of narrative exposition.

The responses revealed a strong consistency in how participants understood the system. All participants correctly identified reincarnation as a core mechanic and recognized that abilities persist across lifetimes, even when explicit memory does not. This suggests that the concept of persistent identity through systemic continuity was successfully communicated. Participants described the soul as carrying knowledge or skill forward, indicating that the mechanics themselves conveyed the idea of inherited experience without requiring detailed narrative explanation.

Participants also consistently identified the existence of two forms of death: a reversible cycle through reincarnation and a permanent form of loss tied to specific conditions. The recognition of this distinction demonstrates that the system effectively communicates irreversibility as a meaningful rule, rather than as a hidden or abstract concept. In particular, the condition that death during a high-risk state results in permanent loss was understood across all responses, indicating that the relationship between power and consequence is clearly embedded within the mechanics.

Another significant pattern in the responses concerns the interpretation of power. Rather than perceiving power as a form of progression or empowerment, participants consistently interpreted power as inherently risky rather than empowering. As one participant stated, "power = danger, not safety," while another noted that "the better you are, the more you're risking everything." This suggests that the system successfully communicates consequence as a core principle of world logic. This reflects a key design intention of the system: to frame strength not as accumulation, but as increasing exposure to irreversible consequence. The fact that this interpretation emerged without explicit narrative framing suggests that the mechanics successfully communicate thematic meaning through structure alone. This also

relates to discussions of consequence and ethical interpretation in games, where rule structures shape how actions are understood as meaningful or meaningful through their consequences (Sicart, 2009; Nay and Zagal, 2017).

The feedback also revealed how identity is interpreted within the system. Participants described identity as something that persists across lives in the form of instinct, ability, or emotional residue, even in the absence of conscious memory. This aligns with the project's aim to explore identity as a systemic construct rather than a purely narrative one. One participant described the system as "sad," noting that relationships and memories are lost despite continuity at the level of the soul. This emotional interpretation indicates that the mechanics not only communicate structure but also evoke thematic responses related to loss, continuity, and existential weight. This connects to Isbister's discussion of how game design can shape emotional experience through systems and interaction (Isbister, 2016).

Importantly, participants were able to infer these elements without being provided with narrative context, suggesting that the mechanics themselves function effectively as worldbuilding tools. At the same time, some responses highlighted areas of ambiguity, such as the precise relationship between memory and identity or the exact boundaries of the system's rules. These moments of uncertainty are valuable, as they indicate where the system may require further clarification or refinement. This aligns with Aarseth's concept of cybertext, which frames structured texts and systems as requiring interpretive engagement, and supports Murray's argument that procedural systems can communicate narrative logic through structure rather than exposition (Aarseth, 1997; Murray, 1997).

From a reflective perspective, the integration of persistent and inherited mechanics proved effective in generating a sense of systemic coherence. By ensuring that rules operate consistently across the artefact, the world acquires a form of internal logic that can be interpreted and understood independently of explicit explanation. However, the process also revealed the difficulty of balancing clarity and complexity, particularly when designing systems that operate across multiple temporal layers.

Overall, the combination of reflective analysis and external feedback supports the conclusion that inherited and persistent mechanics can meaningfully contribute to worldbuilding without reliance on explicit exposition or traditional progression systems. The responses demonstrate that participants were able to infer core aspects of the world's structure, identity logic, and thematic direction directly from the mechanics. This suggests that such systems can function as foundational narrative devices, shaping both interpretation and emotional engagement through rule-based design.

7 Data and Analysis

7.1 Presentation of Data

The data collected for this study consists of two primary sources: the *Soul Art* artefact itself and qualitative feedback gathered through a small-scale exploratory pilot test.

The artefact data includes narrative chapters, mechanic descriptions, lore documentation, and character profiles developed throughout the production of *Soul Art*. Across the artefact, recurring patterns related to persistence, inheritance, and irreversible consequence appear throughout multiple chapters and narrative arcs.

Characters repeatedly demonstrate inherited instincts, recurring combat tendencies, and familiarity with techniques that are not consciously remembered within their current lifetime. Similar patterns appear through the recurring use and recognition of inherited Soul Arts across different narrative situations.

Irreversible mechanics also recur throughout the artefact. High-cost abilities associated with permanent consequences consistently influence character behavior, conflict escalation, and decision-making across multiple chapters.

In addition to artefact observations, a pilot feedback session was conducted with three participants. Because the participant group was small, the feedback is treated as exploratory and qualitative rather than as empirical validation. The participants were not selected simply as personal acquaintances, but because they could provide relevant interpretive responses to a speculative game and narrative system. Their familiarity with games and fantasy-oriented worldbuilding made them suitable for identifying whether the system's core rules communicated persistence, identity, risk, and consequence clearly enough to be understood outside the full narrative context. Participants were provided with a simplified explanation of the *Soul Art* system and asked questions concerning how the world functions, how death operates, what distinguishes the system from traditional fantasy settings, and what risks are associated with power within the world.

All participants identified reincarnation and persistence as central aspects of the system and also consistently described the soul as carrying abilities, instincts, or identity across lives even when explicit memory is absent. Participants also identified the distinction between ordinary death and permanent destruction. Another recurring pattern within the feedback concerned the interpretation of power. Participants frequently described power as risky, burdensome, or dangerous rather than purely empowering while additionally responding to the system in emotional terms.

Together, the artefact observations and participant responses provide the basis for the following analysis section.

7.2 Analysis of Data

The findings from both the *Soul Art* artefact and the participant feedback suggest that inherited and persistent mechanics can function effectively as worldbuilding structures within a narrative artefact. Across both sources, mechanics were consistently interpreted not simply as functional systems, but as structural expressions of the world's logic, continuity, and thematic direction.

A central finding concerns the role of persistence in constructing continuity across the world of *Soul Art*. Rather than relying primarily on exposition to communicate history or metaphysical rules, the artefact embeds continuity directly into its mechanics. Reincarnation, inherited abilities, and recurring instincts communicate that actions and identities extend beyond individual lifetimes. This aligns with Bogost's concept of procedural rhetoric, in which systems communicate meaning through operational logic rather than descriptive explanation (Bogost, 2007).

The participant responses reinforce this interpretation. Participants inferred broader world logic from the mechanics alone, despite being given only a simplified overview of the system. This suggests that the mechanics successfully communicated continuity and persistence without requiring extensive narrative exposition, directly supporting the research question.

The findings also indicate that inherited mechanics contribute to identity construction through systemic continuity rather than explicit characterization alone. Recurring instincts, inherited abilities, and repeated behavioral patterns reinforce identity across reincarnated lives. This reflects Gee's concept of projective identity, where identity emerges through interaction with systems and structures rather than solely through authored narrative (Gee, 2003).

Participant responses further demonstrated emotional interpretations of the mechanics. The system was frequently associated with loss, sacrifice, and existential burden rather than empowerment alone. One participant described the world as "sad," while others associated strength with increasing danger and irreversible consequence. These responses suggest that the mechanics communicated thematic meaning structurally rather than through explicit explanation. This also connects to Isbister's work on emotional design, which argues that games can shape emotional responses through design structures and player experience (Isbister, 2016).

Another significant finding concerns irreversible mechanics and their influence on narrative tension. High-cost abilities were consistently interpreted as dangerous and restrictive rather than liberating. This aligns with Sicart's argument that game systems shape ethical and experiential frameworks through their rules and limitations (Sicart, 2009). In *Soul Art*, consequence becomes embedded into the ontology of the world itself, shaping both narrative structure and participant interpretation.

The findings additionally support discussions of systemic worldbuilding proposed by Jenkins and Murray. Rather than presenting the world primarily through descriptive lore, *Soul Art* communicates its metaphysical structure through recurring rule interactions and persistent consequences. Participants consistently understood that the world operates according to fixed systemic principles even without broader narrative context. This reflects Jenkins' discussion of games as narrative architecture (Jenkins, 2004), as well as Murray's argument that digital environments can communicate narrative meaning through procedural and structural properties (Murray, 1997).

At the same time, the analysis revealed certain ambiguities within the system. Some participant responses demonstrated uncertainty regarding the precise relationship between memory and identity, particularly concerning what is retained across reincarnated lives. These ambiguities indicate areas where further refinement or clarification of the system may be beneficial.

Overall, the findings suggest that inherited and persistent mechanics can operate as effective worldbuilding structures within a narrative artefact. The mechanics of *Soul Art* communicated continuity, consequence, identity, and thematic direction through systemic structure rather than explicit exposition alone.

8 Summary of Study

This thesis explored how inherited and persistent mechanics can function as worldbuilding structures within a narrative artefact without relying on explicit exposition or traditional progression systems. Through the design and analysis of the *Soul Art* artefact, the study examined how mechanics such as reincarnation, inherited abilities, and irreversible consequence communicate continuity, identity, and thematic meaning through systemic structure.

The project was situated within the research fields of mechanics-as-narrative, systemic worldbuilding, narrative identity, and research-through-design. Drawing on procedural rhetoric, rules and fiction theory, narrative architecture, procedural authorship, and ethical game systems, the thesis framed mechanics not simply as gameplay systems, but as structures capable of generating narrative meaning and shaping the ontology of fictional worlds (Bogost, 2007; Juul, 2005; Jenkins, 2004; Murray, 1997; Sicart, 2009).

Methodologically, the study adopted a research-through-design and practice-based approach in which *Soul Art* functioned as both a creative artefact and a research instrument. The project combined reflective design analysis with qualitative pilot feedback in order to investigate how participants interpret world logic, persistence, and consequence through mechanics alone.

The study therefore treated creative practice not simply as production, but as a method of inquiry. In line with research-through-design approaches, *Soul Art* was used as an artefact through which design knowledge could be generated, examined, and reflected upon. This follows Frayling's distinction between research *into*, *for*, and *through* art and design (Frayling, 1993), as well as later design research that understands artefacts as capable of producing situated knowledge through their construction and analysis (Zimmerman, Stolterman and Forlizzi, 2010; Gaver, 2012).

The findings suggest that inherited and persistent mechanics can effectively communicate worldbuilding concepts through systemic continuity rather than explicit exposition. Both the artefact analysis and participant responses demonstrated that themes of identity, memory, sacrifice, and permanence were understood through the structure of the mechanics themselves. Participants consistently interpreted the system as one governed by continuity, consequence, and inherited identity, even when provided only with simplified mechanical descriptions.

Overall, the study contributes to ongoing discussions within game studies concerning mechanics-as-narrative and systemic worldbuilding. By examining persistence and inheritance as structural principles rather than progression features alone, the thesis demonstrates how mechanics can function as foundational components of narrative and world construction within a narrative artefact.

9 Discussion of Results

The results of this study suggest that inherited and persistent mechanics can function effectively as worldbuilding structures within a narrative artefact. Through both the development of the *Soul Art* system and the responses gathered during pilot testing, the project demonstrated that mechanics are capable of communicating continuity, consequence, identity, and thematic meaning without relying primarily on explicit exposition.

One of the most significant outcomes of the study was the extent to which participants inferred the world's logic directly from the mechanics themselves. Even when presented only with simplified descriptions of the system, participants consistently identified reincarnation, inherited continuity, and irreversible consequence as defining features of the world. This indicates that the mechanics successfully communicated structural information independently of narrative context. In this regard, the findings support Bogost's concept of procedural rhetoric, demonstrating how systems can communicate meaning through rules and operational structure rather than through direct explanation (Bogost, 2007).

The findings also highlight the importance of persistence in creating a sense of continuity across narrative structures. Rather than functioning solely as progression systems, inherited mechanics in *Soul Art* contribute to the construction of history, identity, and consequence across multiple lifetimes. This continuity allowed mechanics to operate as part of the ontology of the fictional world itself. The repeated presence of inherited instincts, recurring abilities, and long-term consequences reinforced the perception that the world possesses systemic memory rather than existing as a static narrative setting.

Another important result concerns the emotional interpretation of the mechanics. Participant responses frequently described the system as emotionally heavy, dangerous, or tragic. Rather than interpreting power as empowerment alone, participants associated strength with sacrifice, permanence, and existential risk. This supports the argument that mechanics can shape emotional interpretation through structural design rather than relying entirely on narrative exposition or characterization, which aligns with Isbister's discussion of how game design can shape emotional experience (Isbister, 2016).

The project also demonstrated how irreversible mechanics can generate narrative tension through limitation rather than expansion. High-cost mechanics such as permanent soul destruction influenced how participants interpreted conflict, risk, and decision-making within the world. This aligns with Sicart's discussion of systems as ethical and experiential frameworks, where rules shape not only action but also interpretation and emotional response (Sicart, 2009).

At the same time, the study revealed several limitations and challenges. One recurring ambiguity concerned the precise relationship between memory and identity within the reincarnation system. While participants consistently understood that some form of continuity existed across lives, interpretations differed regarding what exactly persists between reincarnations. This suggests that systems centered around inherited identity may require careful balancing between mystery and clarity in order to maintain coherence without over-explaining the world.

Another limitation concerns the format of the artefact itself. Because *Soul Art* currently exists as a written narrative and conceptual system rather than a fully implemented game, the study primarily evaluates interpretive and structural outcomes rather than active player interaction. While the findings suggest that mechanics can communicate worldbuilding

effectively at a conceptual level, implementation within an interactive environment may produce different responses or reveal additional complexities not visible within a narrative-only format.

From a methodological perspective, the results also demonstrate the value of research-through-design and practice-based research for examining mechanics-driven worldbuilding. Rather than treating *Soul Art* only as a finished creative product, the study used the artefact as a site of inquiry, where design decisions, system tensions, and participant responses could be examined as research material. This aligns with Frayling's understanding of creative practice as a way of producing knowledge (Frayling, 1993). Similarly, Zimmerman, Stolterman and Forlizzi (2010) argue that designed artefacts can embody theoretical contributions, while Gaver (2012) emphasizes that research-through-design produces situated insights rather than universal claims. In this study, the insights generated from *Soul Art* are therefore understood as situated findings about how inherited and persistent mechanics may function as worldbuilding structures within a narrative artefact.

This also means that the value of the artefact lies not only in whether it is "successful" as a story or potential game, but in how its development reveals design possibilities, tensions, and limitations within mechanics-driven worldbuilding.

Despite these limitations, the results demonstrate the potential of practice-based narrative artefacts as tools for investigating mechanics-driven storytelling and systemic worldbuilding. The project shows that mechanics do not need to function solely as gameplay systems or progression structures. Instead, inherited and persistent mechanics can operate as foundational narrative principles capable of shaping identity, consequence, emotional interpretation, and the perceived logic of a fictional world.

10 Future Research

While this study focused on the conceptual and structural analysis of inherited and persistent mechanics within a narrative artefact, several opportunities for future research emerged throughout the project. The findings suggest multiple directions for expanding both the *Soul Art* system itself and the broader study of mechanics-driven worldbuilding within game studies.

These future directions are significant because the current study examines mechanics primarily at the level of conceptual and narrative structure. A further development of the project would allow inherited and persistent mechanics to be studied not only as designed rules, but also as experienced systems. This would extend the research from reflective artefact analysis toward questions of player involvement, embodiment, and emotional interpretation. Calleja's (2011) concept of incorporation is relevant here, as it describes how players become involved in game worlds through spatial, affective, and embodied engagement. Similarly, Isbister (2016) argues that game design can shape emotional experience through interaction, suggesting that future research could examine whether the emotional weight identified in this study remains present when players actively engage with the mechanics.

One potential direction for future research would involve the implementation of *Soul Art* as an interactive game system. Because the current project exists primarily as a written and conceptual artefact, the study focused on interpretive and structural analysis rather than direct player interaction. A playable implementation would allow for investigation into how players engage with inherited and irreversible mechanics during active gameplay, particularly in relation to decision-making, emotional investment, and long-term behavioural adaptation. Such an implementation could also examine whether the thematic interpretations observed during this study remain consistent within interactive environments. This would connect more directly to studies of player involvement, embodiment, and emotional response in games (Calleja, 2011; Isbister, 2016).

A playable prototype would also make it possible to examine how irreversible consequence affects player decision-making. In the current artefact, mechanics such as Soul Shape and life-force exchange are analyzed as narrative structures, but an interactive version could test how players respond when they must personally choose whether to risk permanent loss for temporary power. This would connect the project more directly to Juul's (2013) discussion of failure in games, while also extending the focus toward forms of failure that are not easily reversible. It would also relate to Sicart's (2009) argument that game systems shape ethical and experiential frameworks, since players would need to interpret risk, sacrifice, and responsibility through action rather than only through narrative observation.

Future research could additionally expand the qualitative evaluation process through larger and more diverse participant groups. The pilot testing conducted within this study functioned as exploratory feedback rather than empirical validation. Broader testing could provide further insight into how different audiences interpret persistence, identity, and consequence within mechanics-driven narrative systems. Comparative analysis between participants familiar and unfamiliar with game systems may also reveal differences in how systemic worldbuilding is interpreted.

Expanding the participant group would strengthen the exploratory findings of this study by showing whether the interpretations identified in the pilot test are shared by a broader audience. Since the current evaluation was intentionally small in scale, future research could compare responses from participants with different levels of familiarity with games, fantasy

narratives, or role-playing systems. This would help clarify whether the mechanics communicate worldbuilding meaning generally, or whether their interpretation depends on prior knowledge of game conventions. Such an approach would still align with research-through-design, as Gaver (2012) and Zimmerman, Stolterman and Forlizzi (2010) emphasize that design research often produces situated insights rather than universal claims.

Another possible area of future research concerns comparative studies between *Soul Art* and existing games that utilize persistent or inherited mechanics. Roguelikes, permadeath systems, legacy mechanics, and narrative games featuring long-term consequence could provide useful comparative frameworks for examining how different forms of persistence shape emotional engagement and world perception. Such studies could contribute to broader discussions concerning continuity, memory, and systemic consequence within game design.

The project also suggests opportunities for further theoretical exploration regarding the relationship between mechanics and identity. While this thesis examined inherited abilities and persistence primarily as worldbuilding structures, future studies could investigate how long-term systemic continuity influences player attachment, role formation, or perceptions of self within interactive systems. This may be particularly relevant in games where progression, memory, or consequence extend across multiple playthroughs or character states.

In terms of the *Soul Art* artefact itself, future development could involve expanding the narrative into additional arcs, refining existing mechanics, or exploring new forms of interaction between systems. Because the current artefact focuses primarily on persistence, inheritance, and irreversible consequence, future iterations could investigate how other mechanics—such as social systems, collective memory, or multiplayer interaction—might further contribute to systemic worldbuilding.

Finally, the project highlights the broader potential of research-through-design and practice-based inquiry within game studies. Future research may continue exploring how narrative artefacts, conceptual systems, and speculative mechanics can function as legitimate forms of design investigation prior to technical implementation. In this sense, *Soul Art* functions not only as an isolated case study, but also as an example of how creative practice can contribute to theoretical discussions concerning narrative systems, mechanics, and worldbuilding. This aligns with research-through-design approaches that treat artefacts as tools for inquiry and knowledge production (Frayling, 1993; Zimmerman, Stolterman and Forlizzi, 2010; Gaver, 2012).

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Appendix A - Soul Art — Core System and Metaphysical Law

The following appendix presents a condensed version of the core system of Soul Art. It outlines the metaphysical rules that structure the artefact and explains how inherited and persistent mechanics operate within the fictional world. This material supports the thesis by giving the reader direct access to the mechanics discussed in the analysis.

Soul Art — Core System and Metaphysical Law

Soul Art is not power granted by gods, technology, or training alone.

It is memory made violent.

Every awakened soul carries an inherited archive: instincts, emotions, and combat knowledge accumulated across lifetimes. The body is temporary. The soul is the weapon.

Awakening unfolds through four irreversible milestones.

I. Blade Call — The First Proof of Self

Every awakened soul is bound to a Soul Weapon.

This weapon is not chosen.

It is recognized.

Through Blade Call, the user manifests their weapon from nothing: a crystallization of identity shaped by past lives. The weapon remembers battles the body never fought.

Blade Call does not bind a soul to a single immutable weapon. Instead, it binds the soul to an Archetype of Combat.

The weapon manifested is the current life's expression of that archetype, shaped by era, culture, body, and circumstance, while remaining spiritually consistent across reincarnations.

The soul remembers what it fights as, not what it holds.

Rules of Blade Call

One Archetype per Soul: a soul cannot change its combat identity.

Form Evolves, Archetype Does Not: the weapon adapts to era, technology, and body.

Symbolic Souls Resist Change: mythic reincarnations, such as Poseidon, Arthur, or Thor, retain iconic forms more often.

Damage to the Weapon Reflects Soul Strain: this does not represent physical injury, but spiritual stress.

Weapon Loss Is a Crisis: losing Blade Call temporarily indicates severe Soul Lockout or fracture.

II. Elemental Affinity — Temperament Given Form

Once the weapon is stabilized, the soul begins to bleed outward.

Each awakened soul possesses an elemental affinity. This affinity is not based on lineage or choice, but on temperament:

Rage burns.

Discipline freezes.

Adaptation flows.

Resolve strikes.

Elemental energy fuses with movement, turning instinct into technique. This is where combat stops being mechanical and becomes expressive.

At this stage, most warriors plateau.

Those who do not move on.

III. Soul Arts — Inherited Techniques

Soul Arts are not invented through study.

They are remembered.

Every soul belongs to an ancestral line: a communal archive of techniques refined across generations. Once conditions align, a user recognizes these arts instinctively.

Characteristics

Soul Arts are named.

Their names are immutable.

Each art carries intent, cost, and risk embedded into its structure.

This is why two people can wield the same Soul Art differently.

The soul interprets.

It does not imitate.

IV. Soul Shape — The Soul Made Real

Soul Shape is not a technique.

It is self-revelation.

When a soul is pushed beyond survival, when identity, will, and memory align under unbearable pressure, the soul manifests its true form.

There are two known classifications of Soul Shape:

A. Soul Shape: Domain — Reality Rewritten

A Domain Soul Shape overwrites the environment.

The world bends.

Sound, color, time, and pressure obey the soul's rules.

Enemies are dragged into the user's internal truth.

Law of Clash

Two domains cannot coexist.

When domains overlap, a Soul Clash occurs.

Both domains collapse violently.

The aftermath often leaves both users broken or dead.

This is why domain users rarely fight each other directly.

It is mutually assured destruction.

B. Soul Shape: Construct — The Soul Armored

A Construct Soul Shape manifests the soul as a tangible object, such as:

Armor

Weapon

External extension of the self

Critical Difference

Constructs do not overwrite reality.

They exist within it.

Because of this:

A construct can exist inside a domain.

No Soul Clash occurs.

The construct resists, adapts to, or defies the domain instead of cancelling it.

The Ultimate Risk

Soul Shape carries a massive risk for one reason:

If a user dies while their Soul is Shaped, the soul dies permanently.

No reincarnation.

No echo.

No return.

The soul shatters under the weight of its own truth.

This is why veterans fear Soul Shape more than death.

And why those who wield it are either legends or warnings.